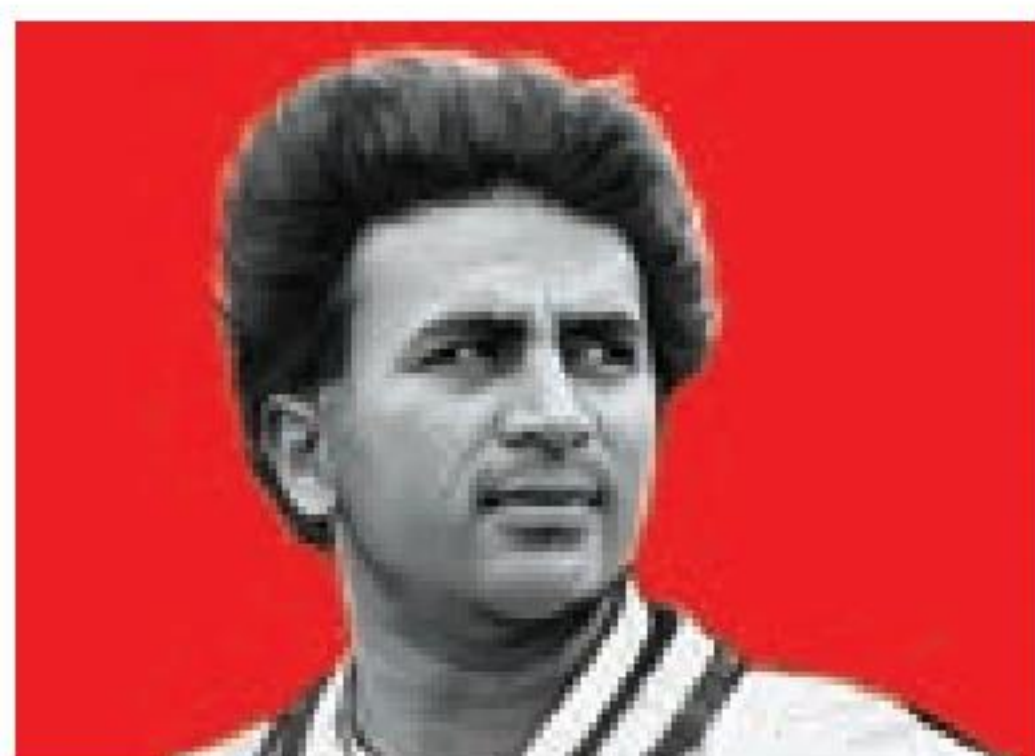




ON THE WRITE LINE

Sunil Gavaskar



FOR MORE
STORIES

IPL SHOULD LOOK AT REDUCING UNCAPPED PLAYER RETENTION FEE BELOW Rs. 4 CRORE

This season has shown that **players bought for crores** in the first cycle and now at a much reduced fee are showing better results.

Ever since the first year of the IPL, the auction of the players has been a life changer for plenty of players. While in the first couple of years there was a limit on what an uncapped Indian player could get, this was removed from the next year when it was found that an uncapped South African player had gone for a humongous amount. Naturally, questions were asked in the IPL Governing Council as to why uncapped Indian players should be restricted to a certain fee, while there was no such limit on the overseas uncapped players. The salary limit for the franchises was also increased, which emboldened them to bid unheard-of numbers for some players. That trend continues and with every increase in the salary cap for a franchise, we will continue to hear of some unknown players going for sums beyond reasonable understanding.

The usual answer to such jaw-dropping figures for uncapped players is that it's market forces at work. As the season progresses, it is realised that yes, it may be market forces at the time of the auction, but it also comes with a healthy dollop of dreamy foolishness that quickly turns into disappointment and then

anger at the hapless player, who had entered the auction at the lowest base price and hadn't asked for the final amount but was simply fortunate to get it.

Yes, almost 10 times out of 10, it's simply good, old luck, grandparents' good deeds or some such omen that gets an uncapped player the crores he gets. The owners rely on their advisers, mostly computer nerds who have little idea of the game but have data at their fingertips and think that is the answer to a player's ability. The data they get is from the many local State leagues that have mushroomed in the country. The scores from these leagues are fed into the computer, and that becomes the basis of their bidding war for a player. Most of them have never actually seen the player play or what the opposition is like. Was it challenging? Was it competitive? Was it demanding is something that doesn't fit into the data at all. How big were the boundaries, how was the pitch and how were the weather conditions? This is another thing that doesn't fit into the data banks perhaps. What was the match situation when runs were scored or when wickets were taken, are things that are hardly taken into account. If there are any